



Ming China

The Ming Dynasty came to power in China in 1368, ending almost a century of rule by Mongol invaders. The new dynasty set about reviving ancient Chinese customs and traditions, and is known for its encouragement of the arts and culture as well as its large-scale building projects.

Under the Ming, the empire was largely peaceful, helped by a smooth transition of power from one emperor to the next. However, Ming rulers were always under threat of invasion. Hongwu, the first Ming emperor, built up an army of more than one million soldiers and set up the world's largest naval dockyards in Nanjing. From the mid-1400s onward, renewed threats of a possible Mongol invasion from the north encouraged the Ming emperors to rebuild the ancient Great Wall.

◀ MING PAINTING

Painting in the Ming era revived the style of the earlier Song Dynasty but with more use of color and calligraphy. Landscapes, flowers, and birds were all popular subjects.

Although the Ming rulers were distrustful of their neighbors, they allowed increasing contact with European powers. Traders brought new crops from the Americas, such as maize and potatoes, as well as chile peppers.

By the start of the 16th century, the Ming faced a new threat from the Manchu people to the northeast, who had united and threatened to invade. Widespread famine, floods, and plague seriously weakened support for Ming rule. In 1644, an army of peasant rebels seized Beijing. The Ming took help from the Manchus to fight the rebels. But the Manchus captured Beijing for themselves, and established a new dynasty—the Qing.